

In 1997, Rosie, the first transgenic cow produced human protein enriched milk, which contained the human alpha lactalbumin. The protein rich milk (2.4 gm/litre) was a nutritionally balanced food for new born babies than the normal milk produced by the cows.

9.1.2 Interferons

Interferons are proteinaceous, antiviral, species specific substances produced by mammalian cells when infected with viruses. Interferons were discovered by Alick Isaacs and Jean Lindemann in 1957. Based on the structure of interferons they are classified as α, β and γ interferons. They stimulate the cellular DNA to produce antiviral enzymes which inhibit viral replication and protect the cells. Interferons could be isolated from blood, but the amount of blood required for isolation of interferons is enormous and not practical. To overcome this issue interferons could be produced by rDNA technology. The yeast *Saccharomyces cerevisiae* is more suitable for production of recombinant interferons than *E.coli*, since *E.coli* does not possess the machinery for glycosylation of proteins. Interferons are used for the treatment of various diseases like cancer, AIDS, multiple sclerosis, hepatitis C and herpes zoster. In spite of the therapeutic applications interferons are not within the reach of the common man due to high cost for its production.

9.1.3 Recombinant Vaccines

Recombinant DNA technology has been used to produce new generation vaccines. The limitations of traditional vaccine production could be overcome by this approach.

The recombinant vaccines are generally of uniform quality and produce less side effects as compared to the vaccines produced by conventional methods. Different types of recombinant vaccines include subunit recombinant vaccines, attenuated recombinant vaccines and DNA vaccines.

Subunit recombinant vaccines

Vaccines that use components of a pathogenic organism rather than the whole organism are called **subunit vaccines**; recombinant DNA technology is very suited for developing new subunit vaccines. It includes components like proteins, peptides and DNAs of pathogenic organisms. The advantages of these vaccines include their purity in preparation, stability and safe use.

Attenuated recombinant vaccines

This includes genetically modified pathogenic organisms (bacteria or viruses) that are made nonpathogenic and are used as vaccines. It is now possible to genetically engineer the organisms (bacteria or viruses) and use them as live vaccines and such vaccines are referred to as attenuated recombinant vaccines.

Edible vaccines are prepared by molecular pharming using the science of genetic engineering. Selected genes are introduced into plants and the transgenic plants are induced to manufacture the encoded protein. Edible vaccines are mucosal targeted vaccines which cause stimulation of both systemic and mucosal immune response. At present edible vaccines for measles, cholera, foot and mouth disease and hepatitis are tested on animals and under developmental phase.

DNA Vaccines

Genetic immunisation by using DNA vaccines is a novel approach that came into being in 1990. The immune response of the body is stimulated by a DNA molecule. A DNA vaccine consists of a gene encoding an antigenic protein, inserted onto a plasmid, and then incorporated into the cells in a target animal. DNA instructs the cells to make antigenic molecules which are displayed on its surfaces. This would evoke an antibody response to the free floating antigen secreted by the cells. The DNA vaccine cannot cause the disease as it contains only copies of a few

XII Std Biology-Zoology Chapter-9 EM.indd 149 23/12/2022 12:58:02